

identity. A family foundation can be an important opportunity to contribute to the family identity. (But beware of philanthropic claptrap. More later.)

Politics

Your family's political stance and activity are important components of the family identity. In our family, we try to avoid politics altogether. We believe in remaining outsiders. We think it is dangerous to try to get on the inside. You risk becoming insiders, looking for handouts and wealth redistribution rather than wealth creation.

Family History

Your family history is a key component of your family's identity. Anything that answers the question of who you are, and what your family is and where it came from, helps build out a sense of being special and different. Just knowing your lineage and family history helps enrich the family identity.

Beyond that, the family history can also be used as a narrative that helps motivate family members. For example, a story of an ancestor overcoming some sort of obstacle can be inspiring for family members. Of course, the story can't be made up. It should be basically true. But as we all know, the truth is remarkably elastic. You should highlight stories and themes that show your family in the light you want it.

This helps you establish what is called a "family brand." It's a way of identifying your family and a simple way—like a cattle brand—of keeping track of who you are and why you are different. Branding can guide the family self-image and help family members reach their potential. But it has to be a real potential. You can't simply invent family characteristics, inclinations, and skills that don't exist. That would be counterproductive.

But there are plenty of things that you have control over that can be expressed as a part of your family brand.